ANDHRA PRADESH/ CRIME

MURDER AND THE FIRST FAMILY

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BLOODY TIES?
(Top) Kadapa MP Y.S. Avinash Reddy; victim Vivekananda Reddy

Four years after the murder of former Andhra Pradesh minister Y.S. Vivekananda Reddy, the ruling YSR Congress and Chief Minister Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy's family continue to be embroiled in the case. The CBI, in a 38-page affidavit filed in the Telangana High Court on February 22, pointed the finger at Jagan's cousin and current Kadapa MP Y.S. Avinash Reddy and his father Y.S. Bhaskar Reddy. The agency alleges that the duo, along with one of their men, D. Siva Sankar Reddy, hatched the plot to kill Vivekananda.

The victim was Jagan's paternal uncle, the younger brother of his father and former chief minister of united Andhra Pradesh, the late Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy. He was also Bhaskar Reddy's cousin. Vivekananda was found mysteriously murdered at his home in Pulivendula, a small town in the Kadapa district of Rayalaseema region, on March 15, 2019, a month before the last assembly election. The murder—he was axed to death—was apparently an inside job. The CBI, citing circumstantial evidence, claims Avinash and his father used the other accused in the case—Yerra Gangi Reddy, Sunil Yadav, Dastagiri and others who worked for the ex-minister—to kill him.

The Andhra government had constituted three special investigation teams (SITs), but had failed to make any breakthroughs. The case would have gone cold if not for the efforts of the victim's daughter, Dr Narreddy Suneetha, who moved the courts for a CBI investigation. "To my knowledge, this is a political murder. The state's investigation agency probed the case for nine months, but was unable to identify the culprits. This is why I wanted the CBI to take over," says Suneetha, adding that she got no help from the state government "even though our family members are part of the ruling party in Andhra Pradesh".

The CBI took over the investigation in July 2020 on the direction of the Andhra Pradesh High Court. Suneetha's petition had also raised suspicions about the involvement of some of her relatives. The CBI filed a chargesheet in the case on October 26, 2021, following it up with a supplementary chargesheet on January 31, 2022. In November last year, the Supreme Court, taking cognisance of the apprehensions raised by Suneetha about not getting a fair trial in the state, transferred the case to a CBI court in Hyderabad, Telangana.

SUNEETHA FEARED SHE WOULD NOT GET A FAIR TRIAL IN HER FATHER'S MURDER CASE IN ANDHRA PRADESH

In their affidavit to the Telangana High Court on February 22, the CBI officials allege that Avinash tried to conceal the murder by creating a fake story of a heart attack and vomiting of blood. On arriving at the crime scene, he had called local political leader K. Shashikala and told her that Vivekananda had died of a heart attack even as the body was lying in the bathroom in a pool of blood. There were visible injuries on the victim's head as well. He also phoned Pulivendula circle inspector Shankaraiah and told him the same story. Despite noticing the wounds on the victim's head, the MP did not insist that the inspector come to the crime scene immediately, says the CBI affidavit.

The CBI also raised concerns about the role played by the Kadapa district police. It said that rather than preserve the sanctity of the crime scene, the police officers moved the body from the bathroom to the bedroom (apparently at the request of "certain interested parties") and then cleaned and bandaged the body. The bloodstains in the bedroom and bathroom were also wiped clean to obliterate crucial evidence.

Further, the CBI affidavit says that on November 18, 2021, Avinash entered the court of the Pulivendula judicial magistrate with his supporters and harassed the investigating officer as he was completing legal formalities of accused Siva Sankar. His supporters also harangued the CBI team as they left the court premises. The CBI claims Siva Sankar was in Avinash's house before and after the murder and had arranged for the bandages to hide the injuries.

As for motive, the agency says Avinash wanted Siva Sankar as an MLC candidate in 2017, but Jagan chose Vivekananda, causing fissures in the family.